

THE ENSEMBLE
Led by Dilnaz Irani, the cast includes Vrajesh Hirjee, Faezah Jalali, Sagar Deshmukh and Bhaskar Sharma

doing so, she navigates a darkly comic journey across the city. Amidst live music and memory, Asha's borrowed identity forces her to stop acting and finally confront her own truth. Mohit Takalkar, who has directed the play, believes that the audience will relate to the idea of connection and how fragile it actually is. "It is a bizarre situation—a woman answering a dead man's phone and slowly getting pulled into his life. But very quickly, it becomes about something we all recognise. It's the way we construct versions of ourselves, the way we misread each other and finally the way we try to hold on to people even when we barely know them," he says.

Ruhl creates a whimsical world with enough elasticity to hold humour, grief, absurdity, even awkwardness all at once. Takalkar believes that in writer Chirag Khandelwal's version, what will stay with the audience is a mix of humour and ache. "The connection is not just with the story. It's with the feeling of navigating people, relationships and even ourselves without fully understanding all of it," he adds.

The director is all praise for the ensemble cast, led by Dilnaz Irani as Asha Parekh, along with Vrajesh Hirjee, Faezah Jalali, Sagar Deshmukh and Bhaskar Sharma. "If someone pushes too hard into comedy or leans too much into emotion, the whole thing tilts. It was about finding a shared rhythm and a certain restraint, trusting that the writing will hold if we don't overplay it," he says. ■

—Deepali Dhingra

Dil Ka Haal Sune Dilwala *will be staged in Delhi at Kamani Auditorium, on May 16 and 17, and in Mumbai at Bal Gandharva Rang Mandir, on May 30 and 31, and at Nehru Centre on Jul. 25 and 26*

spot where he died, its locks broken each time the police haul it back. Rumours spread. A shrine appears. Soon enough, an entire religion has sprouted around a dead man and his bike, complete with devotees, rituals and, inevitably, commerce. It's a fable that could only be set in India, and Pareek tells it with a straight face that makes it funnier.

The film travelled the festival circuit in 2021, garnering critical acclaim. But as any independent filmmaker in India will tell you, making a film is only half the battle—getting it seen is another thing entirely. With no recognisable actors in the cast, distributors weren't biting. It was during this long, uncertain wait that filmmaker Anurag Kashyap gave him a piece of advice: don't sit around waiting for your first film to release, start writing the next one. Pareek took it to heart. "The best thing I could do was to work on the next one," he says. "I'm still working on that movie right now." Eventually, Kashyap, Vikramaditya Motwane, Nikkhil Advani and Vasan Bala came on board as executive producers, and nearly five years after its festival debut, *Dug Dug* finally arrives in theatres on May 8. ■

—Poulomi Das

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